

Praise of the Supremely Noble

Viśiṣṭastava · Toh 1109 · Derge Tengyur

ཁད་པར་དུ་ཕགས་པའི་བསྐྱོད་པ།

Toh 1109 in the Tengyur is a devotional hymn known in Sanskrit as the Viśiṣṭastava and in Tibetan as the Khyad par du 'phags pa'i bstod pa, meaning "The Praise of the Supremely Noble." It is a work of praise poetry addressed to the Buddha, celebrating his complete freedom from faults and his possession of every virtue, while contrasting him favorably with the gods of other traditions such as Viṣṇu and Śiva, whose celebrated qualities are reframed as deficiencies in the light of Buddhist teaching. The text belongs to the stotra genre of laudatory verse, a form widely cultivated in Indian Buddhist literature, and sits within the broader class of hymns and praises found in the Tengyur.

In the language of India: Viśiṣṭastava. In the language of Tibet: The Praise of the Supremely Noble. Homage to all the Tathāgatas.

I have set aside all other teachers
and come to take refuge in you, O Blessed One.
Why? Because you are free of faults
and endowed with every virtue.

Since the world delights in faults
and clings to the possession of virtues,
it sees even faults as virtues
and thus goes for refuge to others.

The people who, with joy and devotion, look to Viṣṇu, the Lord of Pervading Power, and others like him,
and proclaim whatever qualities those gods possess —
all of those proclaimed qualities are, by your teaching, exposed as faults.

The Great God (Śiva) is said to have burned the triple city with a single arrow shot in fury.

Yet it is with your great arrow of primordial wisdom
that the very mind of anger is surely burned away.

The Great God, for his sin of burning the desires,
drew them back again.

But you, entering with the force of primordial wisdom,
cut desire out at its very root and burned it utterly away.

Because the Great God conceived attachment for the supreme goddess of the drop,

four faces arose on him.

But the Tempter's own seductive daughter

could not move so much as the tip of one of your body-hairs.

The Great God could not master even half of what a wife does with the mere force of tears.

Yet you were not deluded by the very pleasures that are the source of ease and joy.

Those armed with discus and lance could not prevail against the forces of māra.

But you, without discus or lance, prevailed by the weapon of loving-kindness.

An old man was pierced by Viṣṇu's arrow, and the Great God's throat turned blue — so these two gods know harm.

Yet you, O Protector, are utterly free of harm.

Viṣṇu, taking on a dwarfish form, deceived the mighty one through trickery.

But you, O hero, though fully knowing deception, do not deceive others in return.

O Protector, you take on miraculous form alone, and by what is seen through this wondrous display, Viṣṇu's traversal of the three worlds is seen to be like the creeping of a worm.

In youth, while still practicing celibacy, Brahmā was said to have consorted with the six-featured one. But you reduced the seven modes of union to nothing but ash.

Brahmā and others are said to declare: "I alone am the one who draws forth the world."

You, perceiving this very thing, taught that both the world and that one too arise from karma.

Indra (Śakra), the lord of the gods, is said to have been deluded by desire when he beheld the woman he could not resist.

Yet you, O courageous one, so that you would not be deluded by desire,
sent away your own queen.

Even the moon is helplessly swallowed
by the arm of Rāhu.

But among all sentient beings within your sovereign domain,
there is not one you render powerless.

The king of men — his pleasure-garments and the rest —
came back again from the forest.

But you, O Sugata, intoxicated with the nectar of solitude,
never returned from it.

The sages are said to have declared
that sacrificial animals are slain for the fire-offering.
Yet you, O sinless one, did not permit
harm to be done even to a single ant.

Others perform the fire-offering of another's life
as an oblation for their own benefit.
But you, for the sake of others alone,
performed the fire-offering of your very own life.

The unendurable curse-fire of the sages
burns great numbers of people.
But with the fire of your primordial wisdom
you burned the very causes of beings' rebirth.

Because a sage's mindfulness is weak from pride,
many words he has spoken are heard to contradict one another,
above and below.
But you, O Sage, are not like that at all.

From the accomplishment of sages' curses,
one infers accomplishment of austerity.
But from the accomplishment of your, O Protector, great compassion,
one infers accomplishment of austerity.

The Great God's mark of sensual desire
was brought down by the curses of the sages.
But you brought down desire itself —
the very root of all ruination.

Island-born and others mostly
simply repeat whatever others have said.

You taught the uncommon Dharma
that you yourself had realized in your own heart.
The tīrthikas recite the words of their Vedas
only in seclusion.

You proclaimed and taught the Dharma
with the voice of a lion's roar.
The Sāṃkhya teacher Bharadvāja,
though he beheld that very reality,
was altogether attached to spring —
yet even your disciple, a woman, was not ensnared by desire.

The owl-priest taught that generosity
should be given to those who are distinguished, not to the lowly.
But you, O Protector, through your compassion,
declared that one should give even to a dog.

Through the austerities of the body,
the naked ones seek to undo the knots.
But you, O Protector, hold that through austerity of mind
the knots are to be undone.

The logicians seek to establish things
as existing independently, without reliance on anything else.
But you, O Master of Words, rightly taught
that nothing whatsoever exists without dependence.

It is said that Necu, having extracted the sun,
taught that liberation exists thereby.
But you attained nirvāṇa
and departed to no place whatsoever.
Liberation arises in another's stream,
and Necu traveled another path.
Yet your disciples, too, arrive
by the very same path from which you yourself departed.

The Viṣṇuites seized sixty thousand women.
But you, O Teacher who have transcended the world,
have no ego and no seizing.

At Kāśī, Mṛgārikā underwent complete transformation
by attachment to flourishing.
But though you dwelt in a household,
no bewildering demon of ruin could overpower your faculties.
Flourishing, tormented by desire and agitation,
was pierced by the prick of women.
But though you dwelt as a householder,
you were never one who became entangled and troubled by the outside world.

It is said that for the sake of his beloved wife,
one crossed to the far shore of the ocean.
But you renounced eighty thousand women
and departed to the forest.

Viṣṇu began to harm
Karna, Subhadra, and the rest, who were hard to conquer.
But you, intending benefit for all sentient beings,
even gave up your own life.

Viṣṇu, through deception,
took possession of the earth in three strides —
that very earth which you, O Protector, intend to liberate
you relinquished entirely, down to its very root.

Priya, by his arrows that take life,
rid the world of its kings
and thereby gained renown —
but that renown does not belong to your teaching.

Ill repute and the ochre robe:
these are the glories for whose sake one goes to battle.
But you embraced them like a sword
and departed, having cast away all cruelty.

When your teaching is found,
the Great God (Śiva), wandering in the forest of ashoka trees,
conducts himself like a master of yoga —
yet acts as one who does not know.
Brahmins even now still proclaim him
"the sense-deprived shrew."
But the renown of your having attained the highest fruit
is proclaimed by Śakra (Indra) himself.

The Viṣṇuītes, seized by panic at the black-and-white,
entered in confusion beneath the throne of Kuntī.
O Lord, you have none who could anywhere intimidate you.

It is heard that the Lord of creatures lay
with his own daughter.
But you, O Sage, your disciples too —
their holy life is without fault.

Brahmins teach that virtue and vice
are transferred through giving and receiving.
But you taught that what has been done does not go to waste,
and that what has not been done is never encountered.

The characteristics of the self, as taught by the yellow-robes,
were thoroughly investigated by those endowed with knowledge.
You taught that if the self is as they say,
then the self would be possessed of impermanence.

The Jainas declare the self
wholly distinct from consciousness and from others.
But you taught that if there were no consciousness,
it would follow that it is like a piece of wood.

The naked ones speak of the life-force
as contracting and expanding in accordance with the body's measure.
But you taught that on that view
it would be utterly destroyed in one direction.

Brahmins taught that the cause of beings
is a permanent, eternal person.
But you taught that there is no such thing whatsoever
as a cause that could be called "permanent."

The sixty thousand poisonous sons
of the great self —

Were burned by the mere glance of the yellow-robes.
Yet even toward them you showed compassion.
Those very yellow-robes, through their knowledge,
declared that beings are born from the Primordial (Skt. pradhāna).
You proclaimed that the birth of beings
arises from afflictions and karma.

The yellow-robés and others say
that the self of liberation is the cause of existence.
Since you have passed into peace,
there are countless ones who have entered and vanished, as it were.
Certain non-Buddhists claim
that liberation possesses a place of going.
Wherever there is a going, that is saṃsāra —
this you understood and taught.
The naked ones say that places of pleasure, enclosures,
and walls are causes of sin.
You, the omniscient one, yourself
declared those very things to be causes of merit.
It is said that a subtle life-force migrates
from body to another body.
You taught that there is no life-force
that is other than and separate from the body.
The Vaiśeṣikas say that one killed in battle in anger
passes to a happy destiny.
You, O Protector, taught
that the mind in that very moment is a lower realm.
The gray-clad ones individually claim
that merely reciting their scriptures generates merit.
Those who traverse what is not to be traversed —
such people disparage your teaching.
Śiva (Varuṇa), the drying lord, the proximate lord,
the fierce one and others, out of fear,
and to threaten, perpetually carry weapons.
You are fearless and you do not threaten.
Since you are one whom no one intimidates
and who intimidates no one,
you alone bear no weapon.
Therefore you are exalted above all beings.
The words of afflicted speakers —
the Vedas and similar texts —
are for the most part contradictory above and below.
Your speech, born of omniscience,
while other treatises, the works of others,

are for the most part self-contradictory from beginning to end,
your own system of doctrine
is without fault from beginning, middle, to end.
They say that Dharma and the desire for it
should not be given to the common and low-born,
granting them intelligence.
Yet you, out of compassion, taught the sacred Dharma
even to outcastes.
Who would rely on the bad
having abandoned the good and noble trees?
If you, who have attained freedom from attachment, were to dwell,
what wise one would bow to another teacher?
The yellow-robcs, while engaged with sense-objects,
claim to become wisdom and to be free of sin.
You taught: how can there be liberation
for those thoroughly immersed in afflictions?
The accumulations of merit that have been performed —
their complete dedication to sentient beings —
what you, the Blessed One, spoke of
is not taught in any other treatise.
Offering to divine images and sacrificial oblations
in which sentient beings are killed —
worldly people seek this as Dharma.
But your teaching utterly rejects these things.
For one who perpetually harms living creatures,
how can there be Dharma?
You, the Chief, with your own life
have excellently protected sentient beings.
Born of the Śākya royal lineage, you
regarded as sacred Dharma:
truthfulness, non-deception,
pure conduct, self-discipline,
and loving-kindness.
Though those who are steeped in the Vedas say
that openly encountering an enemy in battle and slaying him
is something to be spoken of in the world,
you taught that one should have compassion even toward enemies.

The instruction was given to the youth
that he should skewer his maternal uncle with a spear.
You, O Hero, with the weapon of wisdom
severed the net of afflictions.
Viṣṇu was not able
to fully protect even his own kin.
You, O Chief, have striven
to protect all sentient beings.
Knowing the danger composed by the elder,
Viṣṇu was thoroughly ruined and destroyed.
Among all sentient beings,
there is not one who does not feel affection for you, O Sage.
Viṣṇu's own kinsmen and retinue
were struck down in mutual retaliation.
All your kinsmen and retinue
you fully liberated from saṃsāra.
In the system of the non-Buddhists —

The more and more I reflect upon it,
the more and more, O Protector, my mind
has come to faith in you.
Thus those who hold the ruinous views
of philosophical schools that fall short of omniscience
— minds wrecked by such wrong speculations —
even they cannot perceive you, O Teacher,
who are utterly without fault.

The gods, brahmins, and Vedic scholars of the world
who speak in enmity, saying "This Śākya" and such things —
that speech is a fault that falls back upon themselves alone.
Why do they think this way? Because your teaching
brings those who are happy to the very state of happiness.
That is why, O Lion among speakers,
beings delight in your system and doctrine.

By thus fully proclaiming your true qualities
in all these ways,
may whatever merit I have gained thereby
cause the wandering world to become like you.

By the virtue I have accumulated
through composing this praise called "The Supremely Noble Praise,"
may all wandering beings
turn toward the path of awakening.

The Supremely Noble Praise, composed by the master Āryadeva, is complete.

Translated by the Indian scholar Sarvajñādeva and the great revising translator, the monk Rinchen Chok. Later it was translated, revised, and finalized by the monk Paltsek Rakṣita.

Translator's Notes

- The title Viśiṣṭastava, rendered as "The Praise of the Supremely Noble," is a Sanskrit hymn of praise that compares the Buddha favorably with the great Hindu deities, particularly Śiva, Viṣṇu, and Brahmā. This is a well-known polemical-devotional genre in Indo-Tibetan literature.

The phrase "the six-featured one" refers to Kārttikeya (Skanda), the six-faced son of Śiva, with whom Brahmā is here accused of improper conduct — a polemical inversion of brahmanical mythology.

"Island-born" at the close refers to Vyāsa (Kṛṣṇadvaipāyana), the legendary compiler of the Vedas and Purāṇas, whose name derives from his legendary birth on an island. The verse is incomplete at the end of the transmitted passage.

The line about Rāhu swallowing the moon is a reference to the Indian mythological explanation of eclipses, used here to contrast Śakra's helplessness with the Buddha's sovereign power over all beings.

- The passage contains a series of pointed comparisons between the Buddha and various non-Buddhist teachers and traditions. Several proper names and allusions deserve mention.

"Bharadvāja" here refers to the Sāṃkhya teacher of that name. The verse is compressed and the precise referent of "spring" and "attachment" is not entirely transparent; the general sense is that Bharadvāja remained bound by sensual attachment whereas the Buddha's female disciple did not.

"Necu" appears to be a transliteration of a non-Buddhist teacher's name whose exact Sanskrit original is uncertain; the reference to "extracting the sun" is likely a mythological claim about liberation through some cosmic feat, contrasted with the Buddha's non-localized nirvāṇa.

"Mṛgārikā" at Kāśī is a figure associated with Vaiśālī in some sources; the Tibetan reads "Kashi Dzema Gamo," suggesting a woman named or epitheted "Joyful Beauty of Kāśī." The Sanskrit behind this name is not fully certain.

"Karṇa, Subhadra, and the rest" renders a Tibetan phrase meaning "Karṇa, Subhadra, and so on" — figures from the Mahābhārata tradition against whom Viṣṇu acts.

"Priya" here may be a shortened reference to a figure such as Jarāsaṃdha or another warrior-king; the precise identity is uncertain from the text alone.

"The black-and-white" that causes the Viṣṇuites to panic likely refers to the Buddhist monastic robes or a symbolic standard, but the exact referent in the polemical context is not fully certain.

"Kuntī" here likely refers to the throne or seat associated with the Kaurava side in the epic context, not the mother of the Pāṇḍavas; the precise allusion is uncertain.

The final verse is incomplete as given, breaking off mid-sentence with the sixty thousand sons of "the great self" — this is a reference to the myth of the sixty thousand sons of Sagara in the Purāṇic tradition.

- The passage contains an intriguing reference to "Śiva (Varuṇa), the drying lord, the proximate lord." The Tibetan reads "བླ་མ་འདྲིལ་བུ་ལྷ་མོ་འདྲིལ་བུ་ལྷ་མོ་འདྲིལ་བུ་ལྷ་མོ་" — literally "the drying one, the lord, the proximate lord, the fierce one." These are likely epithets of Indra or a cluster of Vedic-Purāṇic deities rather than a single deity; "the drying lord" may be Varuṇa or a similar deity associated with drought and punishment. Without additional context it is not possible to resolve with certainty which deity or deities are intended. The translation renders these as epithets in sequence following the Tibetan.

The line rendered "there are countless ones who have entered and vanished, as it were" (འདྲིལ་བུ་འདྲིལ་བུ་འདྲིལ་བུ་འདྲིལ་བུ་འདྲིལ་བུ་) is somewhat compressed; "entered and vanished" refers to those who have died or been extinguished — possibly a polemical reference to followers of rival schools who have perished without attaining liberation.

- The colophon names two translation stages: an initial rendering by the Indian paṇḍita Sarvajñādeva together with the Tibetan lotsāwa Rinchen Chok, and a subsequent revision and finalization by Paltsek Rakṣita, a well-attested early Tibetan translator of the Imperial period. The attribution of the root text to Āryadeva (here called "the master Mthobtsun Drub") is worth noting: the epithet འཇམ་དཔལ་འཇམ་དཔལ་འཇམ་དཔལ་འཇམ་དཔལ་ is an honorific rendering of the name Āryadeva. The stanza on those who "speak in enmity, saying 'This Śākya'" refers to non-Buddhist critics who dismissed the Buddha by his clan name alone, and their hostile speech is characterized as a self-incurred fault rather than a genuine refutation.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.